

Institutional Identity and History

The University of Karachi, commonly known as Karachi University, is the premier public research university of Karachi, Sindh, Pakistan. It is recognized globally and is positioned within the top 8.9% of universities worldwide according to the Center for World University Rankings for 2025, while maintaining a ranking of 13th nationally within Pakistan. The QS World University Rankings for 2026 places the institution within the 1001 to 1200 bracket globally.

Operating as both an educational and an affiliating examining body, the university influences the academic trajectories of tens of thousands of students annually. The internal academic architecture is immense, comprising over 50 distinct academic departments across multiple faculties including Arts and Social Sciences, Science, Islamic Studies, Engineering, Law, Pharmacy, Management, and Education.

Campus Infrastructure

The University of Karachi operates from its main campus located on University Road, Karachi. The campus houses all primary faculties and departments under a single institutional body. The university also functions as an affiliating university, overseeing the academic standards of numerous colleges across the city and province.

Academic Programs

The university offers a vast range of undergraduate and postgraduate programs spanning sciences, humanities, professional disciplines, and applied fields. Programs are offered in

both Morning and Evening shifts. The Morning shift serves as the standard regular program, while the Evening shift functions as a supplementary, revenue-generating parallel offering.

Bachelor of Science Programs — Morning

The university offers Bachelor of Science programs across four broad pricing tiers based on discipline, laboratory requirements, and market demand. These include programs in Arabic, Bengali, Islamic History, Persian, Philosophy, Sindhi, Urdu, Islamic Learning, Usool-ud-Din, Quran and Sunnah, Chinese, History, Library and Information Science, Pakistan Studies, Political Science, Social Work, Women's Studies, Education, Special Education, Digital Media Marketing, Economics, Economics and Finance, English, International Relations, Mass Communication, Psychology, Sociology, Teacher Education, Applied Physics, Botany, Genetics, Geography, Geology, Health and Physical Education, Mathematics, Marine Science, Physics, Statistics, Zoology, Applied Chemistry, Biochemistry, Biotechnology, Chemistry, Food Science, Institute of Space Science and Technology, Microbiology, Physiology, Poultry Science, Public Health, Financial Mathematics, Computational Mathematics, Human Nutrition and Dietetics, Criminology, Public Administration, Actuarial Science and Risk Management, Environmental Studies, Agriculture and Agribusiness Management, Chemical Engineering, Sports Business Management, Visual Studies, Computer Science, Artificial Intelligence, School of Law, Petroleum Technology, Karachi University Business School offering Bachelor of Business Administration, and Doctor of Pharmacy.

Bachelor of Science Programs — Evening

The Evening program offers the same academic disciplines as the Morning program for most departments, with substantially elevated fee structures. Evening admissions are governed by a lower merit threshold, effectively making the financial capacity of the student the primary barrier to entry rather than academic performance.

Entrance Test Based Specialized Programs

For professional and specialized disciplines, the university requires candidates to clear a mandatory entrance test in addition to meeting the intermediate academic percentage requirement. Programs requiring the entrance test include Computer Science, Software Engineering, Doctor of Pharmacy, Karachi University Business School Bachelor of Business Administration, Human Nutrition and Dietetics, Chemical Engineering, Food Science and Technology, Applied Chemistry and Chemical Technology, Applied Physics, Criminology, Doctor of Physical Therapy, Environmental Studies, Public Administration, Teacher Education Bachelor of Education Honors, Petroleum Technology, Special Education, and Sports Business Management.

Admission Policy (2025)

Merit Formula and Admission Categories

The University of Karachi uses a geography-based admission sorting system formally known as the Karachi, Sindh, Pakistan policy, commonly referred to as the KSP policy. This policy stratifies applicants into three sequential priority tiers based on where the applicant completed their Secondary and Higher Secondary Certificate education.

Category Karachi: This is the primary and highest-priority tier. It is reserved for applicants who completed their Secondary Certificate and Higher Secondary Certificate from institutions physically situated within Karachi.

Category Sindh: This is the secondary priority tier, applying to candidates whose educational certificates were obtained from recognized institutions within Sindh province, excluding Karachi.

Category Pakistan: This is the tertiary priority tier, encompassing all remaining applicants whose qualifications were obtained from institutions outside Sindh but within Pakistan.

Admissions are filled sequentially: Karachi category applicants are considered first, followed by Sindh category applicants if seats remain, and finally Pakistan category applicants if further seats are still available. This system has faced significant legislative scrutiny, with provincial oversight bodies directing the university to transition toward a unified, province-wide open merit system. However, the KSP stratification remained deeply embedded in the 2025 admission cycle.

Eligibility Criteria

The university establishes an absolute statutory minimum of 45% in the Higher Secondary Certificate as the floor for eligibility across all open merit programs. Programs under the entrance test based system require candidates to also achieve a minimum score of 50 out of 100 on the university entrance test in order to proceed to academic merit ranking. Certain programs operating under reduced demand conditions have lowered this test minimum to 45, 40, 35, 30, or even 25 in order to fill institutional capacity. A small number of programs are fully exempted from the test requirement.

For the School of Law program, candidates must additionally provide a valid Higher Education Commission Law Admission Test score of a minimum of 50 marks, compounding the entry barrier beyond the standard test.

Application Process

Students must apply through the official University of Karachi admissions portal. The application and processing procedures follow standard public university protocols, with documentation requirements including Higher Secondary Certificate and Secondary Certificate transcripts, national identity documents, and domicile certificates where applicable.

Entry Test Details

The University of Karachi administers its own internal entrance test for specialized and professional programs. The standard passing mark for the entrance test is 50 out of 100. Candidates who score below the required minimum on the entry test are automatically disqualified regardless of their intermediate academic percentage. The entry test acts as a first filter before the academic merit percentage is applied for final ranking.

Fee Structure (Session 2025)

The University of Karachi follows a deliberate tiered pricing strategy for its Morning programs, based on faculty grouping, laboratory infrastructure requirements, and the perceived market value of the degree. All morning program fees include an embedded admission fee of Rs. 1,000. The university has mandated a compounding annual fee escalation of 10% per year for the batch of 2025 onward, meaning the total cost of a four-year degree increases significantly beyond the initial intake fee.

Morning Program Fee Tiers

The lowest fee bracket, ranging from Rs. 26,000 to Rs. 31,000 per semester, covers traditional humanities, classical languages, and theological disciplines. This includes Arabic, Bengali, Islamic History, Persian, Philosophy, Sindhi, Urdu, the Faculty of Islamic Studies programs, Chinese, History, Library and Information Science, Pakistan Studies, Political Science, Social Work, Women's Studies, and Education.

The standard sciences and social sciences bracket, ranging from Rs. 34,000 to Rs. 43,000 per semester, covers programs such as Digital Media Marketing, Economics, Economics and Finance, English, International Relations, Mass Communication, Psychology, Sociology, Teacher Education, Applied Physics, Botany, Genetics, Geography, Geology, Health and Physical Education, Mathematics, Marine Science, Physics, Statistics, Zoology, Applied Chemistry, Biochemistry, Biotechnology, Chemistry, Food Science, Institute of Space Science and Technology, Microbiology, Physiology, Poultry Science, and Public Health.

The specialized and emerging disciplines bracket, ranging from Rs. 52,000 to Rs. 82,500 per semester, covers Financial Mathematics, Computational Mathematics, Human Nutrition and Dietetics, Criminology, Public Administration, Actuarial Science and Risk Management, Environmental Studies, Agriculture and Agribusiness Management, Chemical Engineering, and Sports Business Management.

The elite corporate and healthcare premium bracket, ranging from Rs. 86,000 to Rs. 209,000 per semester, covers Visual Studies, Computer Science, Artificial Intelligence, School of Law which includes an additional Rs. 3,000 Pakistan Bar Council registration fee, Petroleum Technology, Karachi University Business School Bachelor of Business Administration, Doctor of Pharmacy Evening program, and Doctor of Physical Therapy which carries the highest fee of Rs. 209,000 per semester.

Evening Program Fee Structure

The Evening program charges a mandatory non-refundable upfront administrative overhead at the start of each academic year. This consists of an admission fee of Rs. 4,500, an enrolment fee of Rs. 1,500, a development fee of Rs. 2,500, and a refundable caution money deposit of Rs. 1,500, bringing the total initial amount to Rs. 10,000. This Rs. 10,000 is added to the base tuition fee at the time of admission.

Evening tuition fees are substantially higher than Morning fees across all departments. Mass Communication students face a premium of over 117% compared to their Morning counterparts. English and International Relations students face a markup of approximately 66%. Standard sciences such as Microbiology and Biotechnology carry an evening premium of approximately 72%. Computer Science carries an evening premium of approximately 21.5%, while Karachi University Business School Bachelor of Business Administration carries the smallest relative premium at approximately 8%, as pushing those fees further would exceed the financial capacity of the target demographic.

Credential Upgrading and Diploma Programs

The university also offers Bachelor of Science Third Year lateral entry programs through the Evening shift, designed for mid-career professionals and students holding legacy two-year degrees who need to upgrade to a four-year Bachelor of Science equivalent. Fees for Third Year entry broadly mirror the Evening First Year structure.

Additionally, the university offers postgraduate diploma and certificate courses targeting specific professional niches. The Postgraduate Diploma in Computer Science is priced at Rs. 63,000. The Postgraduate Diploma in Human Resource Management is priced at Rs. 45,000. Investigative Psychology and Industrial Psychology diplomas are priced at Rs. 46,500. Certificate courses in Mass Communication, Islamic Banking, Arabic, and Petroleum Technology are standardized at Rs. 17,000 tuition plus Rs. 10,000 admission, totaling Rs. 27,000.

Refund Policy (Higher Education Commission Standards)

First 7 Days of Classes: 100% refund of tuition fees.

8th to 15th Day of Classes: 50% refund.

After 15th Day: No refund.

Admission Fee: Non-refundable under any circumstances.

Historical Closing Merit Data — Morning Open Merit 2025

IMPORTANT NOTE: The following closing percentages reflect the 2025 open merit cycle under the KSP geographical policy. Karachi category closings represent the primary merit pool. Sindh and Pakistan category closings are substantially higher due to the sequential seat allocation model, and should not be compared directly to Karachi category figures.

Programs closing at the statutory minimum of 45% across all categories include Arabic, Audiology and Speech Language Pathology, Geology, History, Islamic History, Islamic Learning, Library and Information Science, Persian, Philosophy, Quran and Sunnah, Sindhi, Special Education, Social Work, Urdu, Usool-ud-Din, and Women's Studies.

Programs with elevated Karachi category closing percentages for 2025 are as follows. Digital Media Marketing for standard intermediate students closed at 76.82%. Digital Media Marketing for Diploma of Associate Engineering holders closed at 79.69%. Psychology for first division holders closed at 78.18%. Microbiology closed at 70.09%. English for students with 60% or above in compulsory English closed at 68.82%. Economics and Finance closed at 67.55%. Biochemistry closed at 67.18%. Genetics closed at 67.18%. School of Law closed at 62.27% with an additional Higher Education Commission Law Admission Test requirement of 50 marks minimum.

Historical Closing Merit Data — Entrance Test Based Programs 2025

Doctor of Pharmacy Morning program closed at 81.18%, representing the highest academic closure in the entrance test based category with a minimum test score of 50 required. Computer Science and Software Engineering both closed at 75.36% with a minimum test score of 50. Chemical Engineering for Diploma of Associate Engineering candidates closed at 75.88% and 74.32% for two separate tracks with test minimum scores of 40 and 50 respectively. Karachi University Business School Bachelor of Business Administration closed at 72.45% with a minimum test score of 50. Food Science and Technology closed at 72.27% for the pre-medical track with a minimum test score of 50. Human Nutrition and Dietetics closed at 71.27% with a minimum test score of 50. Doctor of Pharmacy Evening program closed at 67.64% with a minimum test score of 50. Doctor of Physical Therapy closed at 60.18% with a reduced minimum test score of 45.

Programs that operated with significantly reduced minimum test score requirements include Applied Chemistry and Chemical Technology which offered a track with a minimum test score of 25 closing at 47.36%, Applied Physics with a minimum test score of 25 track, Criminology with a minimum test score of 35 track, Environmental Studies with a minimum test score of 35 closing at 47.55%, Public Administration with a minimum test score of 45 closing at 62.18%, and Teacher Education Bachelor of Education Honors with a minimum test score of 30 closing at 54.73%.

Programs fully exempted from the test requirement include Petroleum Technology closing at 55.00%, Special Education closing at 45.00%, and Sports Business Management closing at 50.18%.

Summary and Context

The University of Karachi remains the largest and most comprehensive public research university in Karachi and one of the most significant higher education institutions in Pakistan. Its 2025 admission cycle reflects an institution navigating a profound transitional period, simultaneously functioning as a guardian of subsidized public education and a revenue-generating commercial enterprise.

The concentration of high closing percentages in Computer Science, Pharmacy, and Business Administration programs, consistently ranging from 75% to 81%, stands in sharp contrast to the total collapse of entry standards to the 45% statutory floor in fundamental sciences and humanities. This reflects a broader cultural shift within the applicant pool, which is increasingly utilizing the university as a vocational conduit for corporate employment rather than foundational academic research.

The Evening program operates functionally as a pay-to-play educational model: by lowering open merit requirements to the 45% floor while simultaneously inflating tuition fees by 60% to 117% over regular morning rates, the university has created a system where financial capital, rather than academic merit, becomes the primary determinant of evening program access.

The KSP geographical policy continues to create stark inequities, with students from interior Sindh facing admission penalties of 20% to 44% higher academic requirements compared to Karachi-domiciled counterparts for the same program and the same remaining seats, a disparity that has drawn significant political and legislative criticism. With compounding 10% annual fee escalations mandated for the 2025 batch onward, the university faces the challenge of replacing geographic exclusion with economic exclusion if structural reforms are not implemented.